to find out what was happening in other parts of the world. But he was too busy consolidating his empire and the big problem that faced him was how to reconcile a proselytizing religion like Islam with the national religion and customs of the people, and thus to build up national unity. He tried to interpret religion in a rational spirit and for the moment he appeared to have brought about a remarkable transformation of the Indian scene. But this direct approach did not succeed, as it has seldom succeeded elsewhere. So not even Akbar made any basic difference to that social context of India, and after him t h e air of change and mental adventure which he had introduced subsided, and India resumed her static and unchanging life.*

**Abul Fazl tells us that Akbar had heard of the discovery of America by Columbus. In the next reign, Jehangir's, tobacco from America reached India, via Europe. It had an immediate and amazing vogue in spite of Jehangir's efforts to suppress it. Throughout the Mughal period India had intimate contacts with central Asia. These contacts extended to Russia and there are references to diplomatic and trade missions. A Russian friend has drawn my attention to such refrences in Russian chronicles. In 1532 an envoy of the Emperor Babar,*